THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

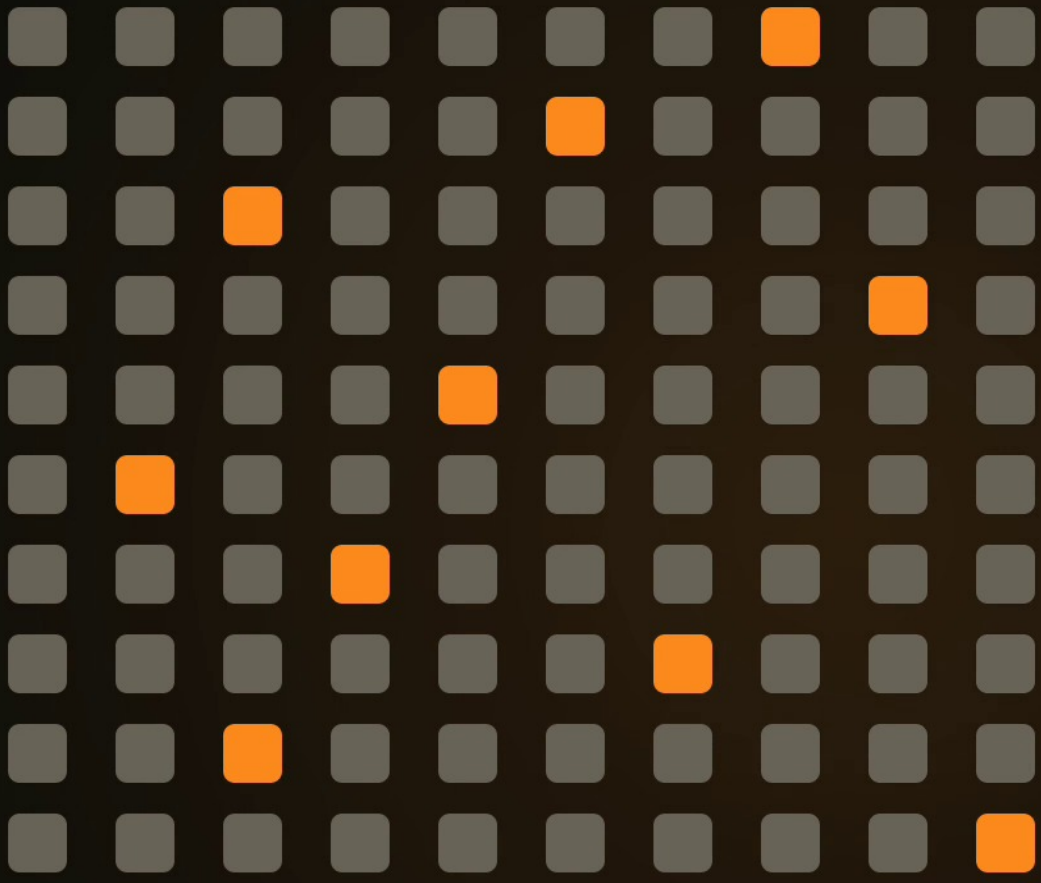
Sturgeon's law

Ninety percent of everything is crud

swipe →

Ivan Rykov

90% of everything is crud



books · movies · cars · your features

Ivan Rykov

A sci-fi writer fights back

Theodore Sturgeon, science fiction author

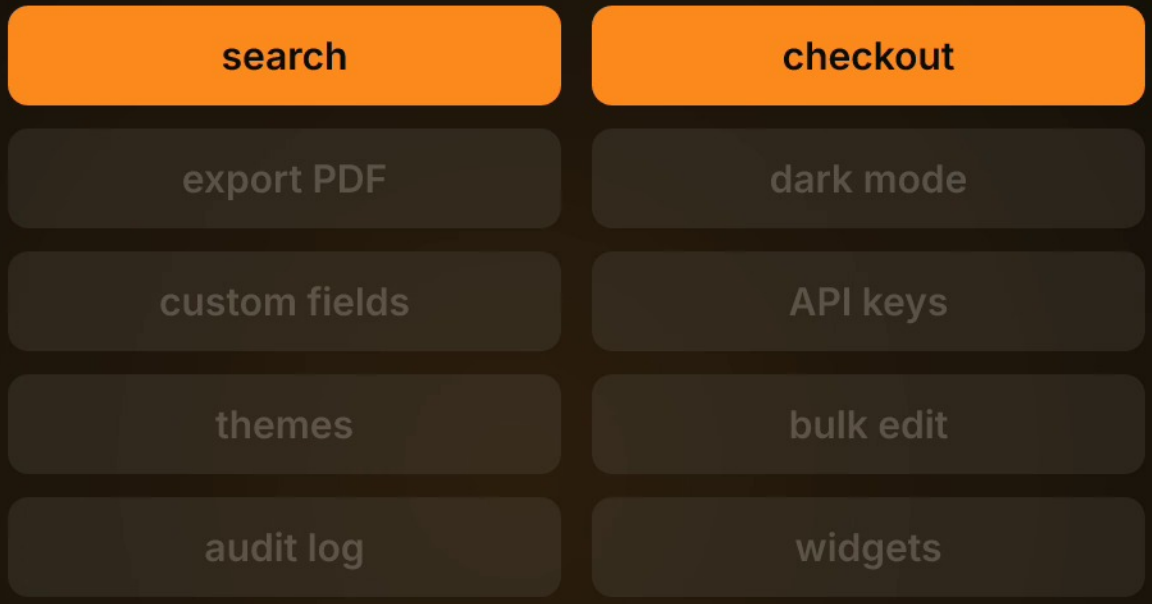
CRITICS
“90% of sci-fi is crud”

THEODORE STURGEON · 1957
“Sure. 90% of everything is crud”

Sci-fi isn’t worse. Everything is mostly bad

Venture Science Fiction column, 1957 · wording paraphrased

Most features go unused

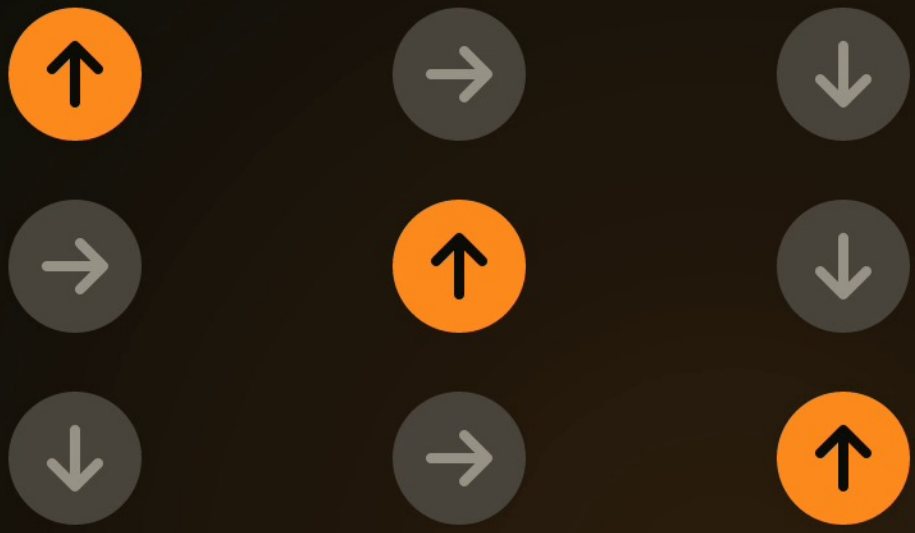


80% rarely or never used

Pendo Feature Adoption Report, 2019 · 615 customer subscriptions
feature names illustrative

Even tested ideas mostly miss

Microsoft A/B experiments



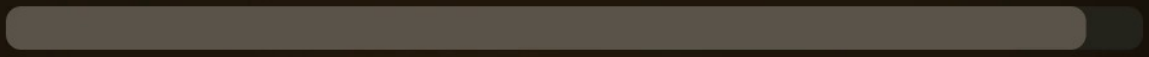
~1 in 3 improved its metric

Kohavi et al., “Online Experimentation at Microsoft”, 2009 · rest: flat or worse

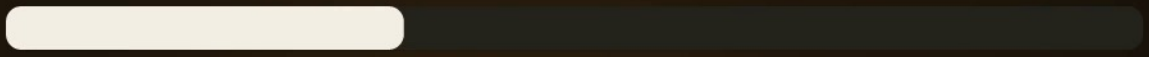
10x engineers don't write 10x code

Code written

busy engineer

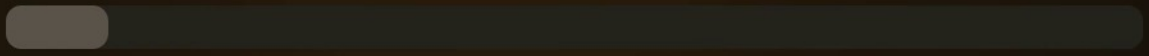


10x engineer



Value created

busy engineer



10x engineer



They pick the 10% that matters

illustration · idea via manager.dev

Push back on the roadmap

Ideas on the roadmap



Ship small versions



Keep what people use



Cut what nobody touches

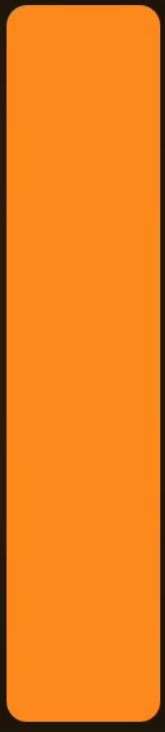
illustration

Ivan Rykov

The crud doesn't go away

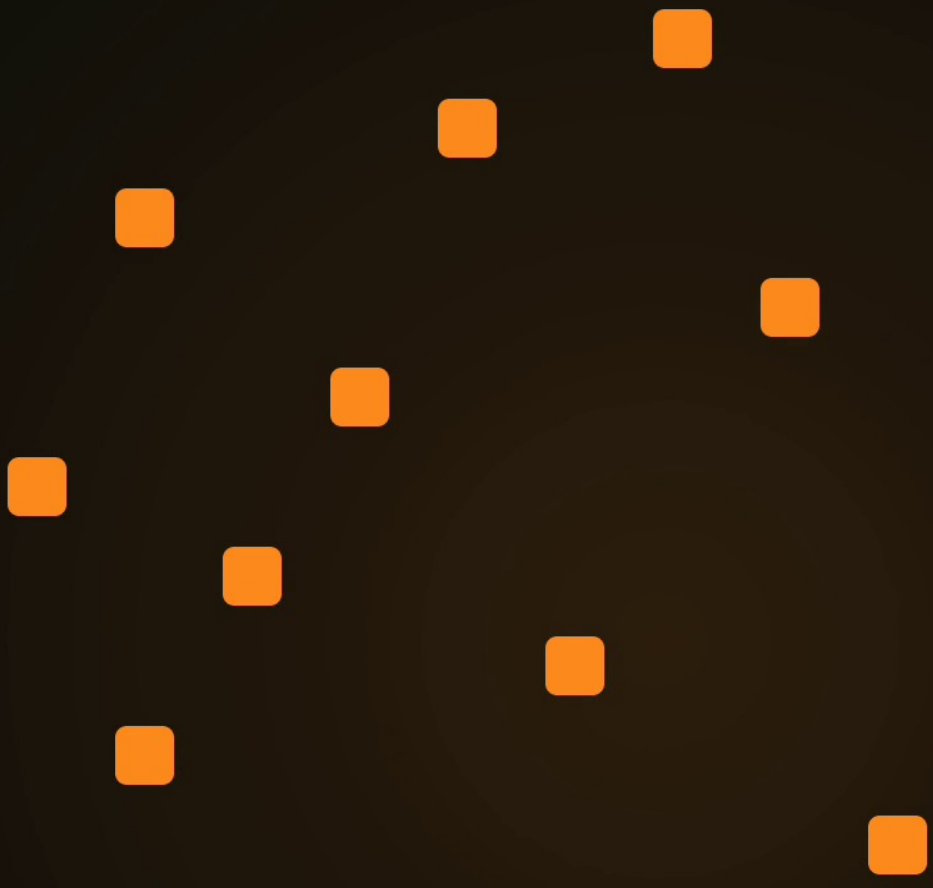
You maintain 100% of it, forever

- widgets
- audit log
- bulk edit
- themes
- API keys
- custom fields
- dark mode
- export PDF
- checkout
- search



maintenance

Find the 10%
Say no to the rest



TAKEAWAY

Find the 10%

Say no to the rest

Sources: Theodore Sturgeon, 1957 · Pendo, 2019 · Kohavi, Crook and Longbotham, 2009

next: the law of triviality